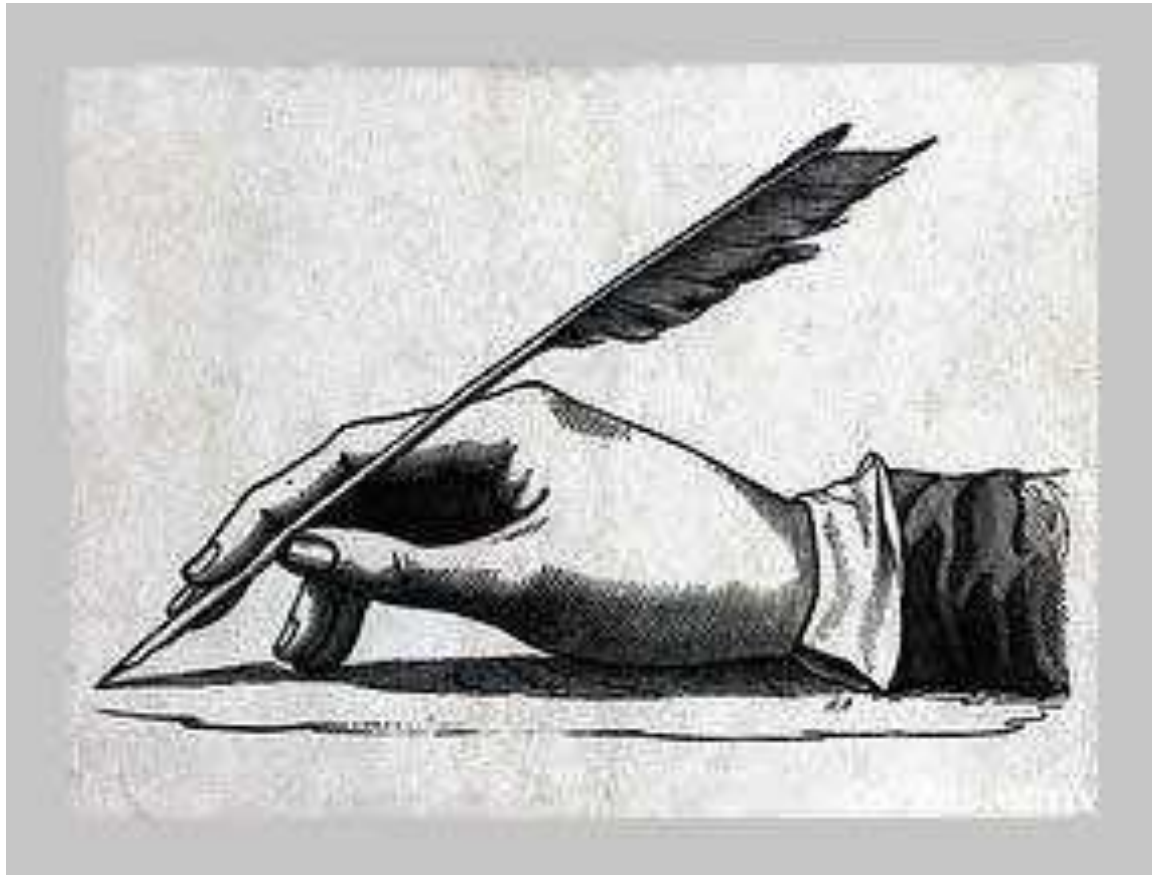


Linguistic Reconstruction of Biblical Hebrew

Avner Ramu



The Bible is the most important book in the history of Western civilization, and also the most difficult to interpret. It has been the vehicle of continual conflict, with every interpretation reflecting passionately held views that have affected not merely religion, but politics, art, and even science.

(From the promo of Robert Carroll's book: *The Bible: Authorized King James Version with Apocrypha*. 1998).

Contents

Introduction

Vowel diacritics

Interchange between vowel letters

ע (y') an unrecognized vowel letter?

להט - לעט (Set ablaze or Devour?)

Words' fusion and words' fission

Phrase erosion and fusion into fewer words

Script related errors

Rhotacismus

Similar sounding letters

Interchange between the bilabials ב - פ (B - P)

Interchange between the velars ג - כ - ק (G - K - Q)

Interchange between Dentals ד - ת - ט (D - Th - T)

Interchange between Sibilants

Sibilants' alternative letters

נ (n) letter issues

Grammar related errors

Word disorder

Metathesis

Superfluous words

Letter insertion

Missing words

Letter deletion

Unintentional word substitution

Letter substitution

Intentional variants and alterations within the text

Dual meaning

Conflicting information and oddities

Modern Hebrew

Conclusion

Introduction

“But now what piety without truth? What truth without the word of God? What word of God without the Scripture” (From the preface to King James Version of the Bible. 1611).

These words reflect some of the basic tenets of all the traditional theologies that “truth and morality are absolute and divine.”

According to the Bible, there was only one manuscript written by God himself (the Greek translator of the Book of Chronicles suggests that God also gave a letter to King David):

ויתן אל-משה ככלתו לדבר אתו בהר סיני, שני לוחות העדות--לוחות אבן, כתבים באצבע אלהים.

“And He gave to Moses, when He had made an end of speaking with him upon mount Sinai, the two tables of the testimony, tables of stone, written with the finger of God” (Ex 31:18).

והלחת--מעשה אלהים המה; והמכתב מכתב אלהים הוא--חרות על-הלחת.

“And the tables were the work of God, and the writing was the writing of God, graven upon the tables” (Ex 32:16).



Julius Schnorr von Carolsfeld (1794-1872)

Unfortunately Moses, in his anger, shattered this unique divine document:

ויהי כאשר קרב אל-המחנה, וירא את-העגל ומחלת; ויחר-אף משה וישלך מידו את-הלחת וישבר אתם תחת ההר.

“And it came to pass, as soon as he came nigh to the camp, that he saw the calf and the dancing; and Moses' anger waxed hot, and he cast the tables out of his hands, and broke them beneath the mount” (Ex 32:19).

The Chronicler tells us that King Solomon constructed all the work of the service of the house of God:

הכל בכתב מיד יהוה עלי השכיל--כל מלאכות התבנית.

“All this [do I David, give you] in writing, as YHWH had made me wise by His hand upon me, even all the works of this pattern” (1 Ch 28:19).

The Greek translator wrote here:

”Dauid gave all these to Salomon in the writing by the Lord’s hand, according to his surpassing understanding to activate the plan.”

St Augustine of Hippo (354-430 AD) said: **“Whatsoever is in the Scripture believe me, is high and divine,”** and many conservatives indeed have taken Augustine’s words to their hearts and believe that God’s spoken words were delivered to humans in the form of the Bible.

Some of the followers of this brand of faith also believe that **“the Bible is totally inerrant.”** However, there are some disputes between those who think that this statement relates only to the content of the Bible, and those who believe that it includes also the written form. It is a fact that the religious thoughts among this last group of believers are largely dependent on their conviction that the written form of the Bible is absolutely error-free, even when a specific verse or a paragraph contradicts the general spirit of the book.

There are major differences and contradictions between the many versions of the Bible, and although each version has its own adherents, we may wonder which version of the Bible “does not err.”

In verse 27:24 of the Massoretic version of the Book of Ezekiel, we read:

**המה רכליך במכללים בגלומי תכלת ורקמה, ובגנזי ברמים; בחבלים חבשים וארזים,
במרכלתך.**

Septuagint

**φέροντες ἐμπορίαν ὑάκινθον καὶ θησαυροὺς ἐκλεκτοὺς δεδεμένους
σχοινίοις καὶ κυπαρίσσινα**

(Bearing commerce in blue and choice treasures bound with cords and cypress wood).

Vulgate

**ipsi negotiatores tui multifariam involucris hyacinthi et polymitorum gazarumque
pretiosarum quae obvolutae et adstrictae erant funibus cedros quoque
habebant in negotiationibus tuis**

(They were your merchants in divers manners, with bales of blue cloth, and of embroidered work, and of precious riches, which were wrapped up and bound with cords: they had cedars also in thy merchandise).

KJV

These [were] thy merchants in all sorts [of things], in blue clothes, and broidered work, and in chests of rich apparel, bound with cords, and made of cedar, among thy merchandise.

NIV

In your marketplace they traded with you beautiful garments, blue fabric, embroidered work and multicolored rugs with cords twisted and tightly knotted.

JPS (1917)

These were thy traffickers in gorgeous fabrics, in wrappings of blue and richly woven work, and in chests of rich apparel, bound with cords and cedar-lined, among thy merchandise.

JPS (1999)

These were your traffickers in choice wares, in wrappings of blue and embroidered work, and in chests of rich clothing, bound with cords and made of cedar, among your merchandise.

As among these versions of the Bible the meaning of this verse differs so widely, we may wonder which of them (if any) transmits the message of the original writer.

Bibles in Hebrew:

Dead Sea Scrolls (~250 BC - 68 AD)

Cairo Codex of the Prophets (896 AD, written by Moses ben Asher)

Codex Leningradensis (1008)

Aleppo Codex (Keter Aram-Zoba) (11th Century)



Codex Aleppo - כְּתָר אֶרֶם צוֹבָא

Judaism and Christianity consider the Bible as divinely given or revealed texts. These sacred texts are referred to as: **כתבי הקודש** - “**Holy writings**” or “**Holy Scripture**.” The earliest reference to 24 books of the Bible appear in the “Latin Esdras” that was probably written first in Hebrew in the first half of the 2nd century AD. This book, as several others that were composed at that time or earlier, was not included in the canons of the Hebrew or the Greek bibles, and is considered as one of the “Biblical Apocrypha” (the Greek ἀπόκρυφος, - apókruphos, means: “hidden”). The Talmudic sages’ term for these books was **ספרים חיצוניים** - “External books.”

However, several decades earlier Josephus wrote (in: Against Apion):

“We have not a countless number of books, discordant and arrayed against each other, but only two and twenty books, ... and of these, five belong to Moses, which contain both the laws and the history of the generations of men until his death ... From the death of Moses, moreover, until the reign of Artaxerxes king of the Persians after Xerxes, the prophets who followed Moses have described the things which were done during the age of each respectively, in thirteen books. The remaining four contain hymns to God, and rules of life of men.”

It is not certain whether Josephus’ twenty-two books represent a different division of the material included by others in twenty-four books, or whether two books were added to the canon after his time. Furthermore, **it is not known when the canon of the Massoretic version of the Bible was set, by whom, and according to which principals.**

The discovery of the “Dead Sea Scrolls” made it clear that at that time (3rd century BC - 1st century AD) there were several versions of the biblical texts (e.g. five versions of the Pentateuch; 4Q158, 4Q364-367). The process of setting the canon must have included judgments about the “most genuine” version and/or combining the “most authentic” parts of different versions. For example: two parallel versions of the Hebrew text of Jeremiah were found in Qumran. One resembles the Massoretic version of the Book of Jeremiah, while the other is closer to the Greek version of this book (which is 1/8th shorter than that found in the Massoretic Bible). It is clear that the process of setting the canons of the Hebrew Bible and the Septuagint relied on different reasoning.

The earliest known citation from the Bible is from the Book of Numbers:

יִבְרַךְ יְהוָה וְיִשְׁמְרֶךָ.
יֵאָר יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וִיחֲנֶךָ.
יֵשָׂא יְהוָה פָּנָיו אֵלֶיךָ וְיִשֶּׁם לְךָ שְׁלוֹם.

“**YHWH will bless you, and keep you.**

YHWH will make His face to shine upon you, and be gracious to you.

YHWH will lift up His countenance upon you, and give you peace” (Num 6:24-26).

[אנכי י]הוה אלהיך אשר [הוצא]תיך מארץ מ[צרים]

[לוא יהיה לך] אלהים אחרים [על פ]ני לוא תעשה [לך פסל]

[וכל תמונה] אשר בשמים ממעל ואשר בארץ [מתחת]

[ואשר במי]ם מתחת לארץ לוא תשתחוה להם [ולוא]

[תעבדם כי] אנכי יהוה אלהיך אל קנא פק[ד עון]

[אבות על בני]ם על שלשים ועל רבעים לשנאי [ועשה]

[חסד לאלפים] לאהבי ולשמרי מצותי לוא ת[שא את]

[שם יהוה א]להיך לשוא כי לוא ינקה יהוה [את אשר]

[ישא את ש]מה לשוא זכור את יום השבת ל[קדשון]

[ששת ימי]ם תעבוד ועשית כל מלאכתך ו[יום השביעי]

[שבת ליהוה] אלהיך לוא תעשה בה כל מלאכה [אתה]

[ובנך ובתך] עבדך ואמתך שורך וחמרך וכל ב[המתך]

[וגרך אשר] בשעריך כי ששת י[מים עשה י]הוה

[את השמי]ם ואת הארץ את הים ואת כל א[שר במ]

[ינח ביום] השביעי עלכן ברך יהוה את [יום]

השביעי ויקדשיו כבד את אביך ואת אמ[ך למען]

ייטב לך ולמען יאריכון ימ[ך על האדמה] אשר]

יהוה אלהיך נתן לך לוא תנאף לוא תרצח לו[א]

[תגנב לוא] ת[ענה ברעך עד שוא לוא תחמוד את]

[אשת רעך לו]א ת[א]ת[א]ת [א]ת ב[י]ת רעך שד[הו ועבדו]

[ואמתו] וש[ורו וחמרו וכל אשר לרעך]

[ואלה החק]ים והמשפטים אשר צוה משה את [בני]

[ישראל] במדבר בצאתם מארץ מצרים שמ[ע]

[ישראל] יהוה אלהינו יהוה אחד הוא וא[הבת]

[את יהוה א]ל[היך בכ]ל [לבבך]...

מקרא

השוואת השינויים מתבססת על נוסח המסורה של המקרא בספר שמות, כשהחלקים השונים משם סומנו בהתאם.

- מקטעים בעלי רקע ירוק - נוסח השונה מנוסח המסורה בספר שמות, והזהה לנוסח המסורה בספר דברים
- מקטעים בעלי רקע סגול - נוסח השונה משני נוסחי המסורה שבשמות ובדברים גם יחד, והזהה לנוסח תרגום השבעים
- מקטעים בעלי רקע תכלת - נוסח ייחודי לפירוט נאש, התואם את צורת הכתיבה של אותה תקופה (כתיב מלא, ועוד).
- מקטעים המוקפים חצאי סוגריים מרובעים - שיחזור משוער של הטקסט המקורי שלא שרד

An interesting remark made by one of the biblical writers is included in the Book of Ecclesiastes:
ויתר שהיה קהלת חכם: עוד למד-דעת את-העם, ואזן וחקר תקן משלים הרבה.

“And besides that Koheleth was wise, he also taught the people knowledge; yea, he pondered, and sought out, and set in order many proverbs” (Ecc 12:9).

The Chronicler remark: **והדברים עתיקים** - “**And the records are ancient**” (1 Ch 4:22), suggests that already in his day (presumably the last part of the 4th century BC), some of the biblical texts were already considered old and possibly were not fully comprehensible. For example:

In the Book of Samuel we read:

**וישב דוד במצדה, ויקרא-לה עיר דוד;
ויבן דוד סביב, מן-המלוא וביתה.**

**“And David dwelt in the stronghold, and called it the city of David.
And David built roundabout from Millo and inward” (2 Sam 5:9).**

The Chronicler re-tells this account as follows:

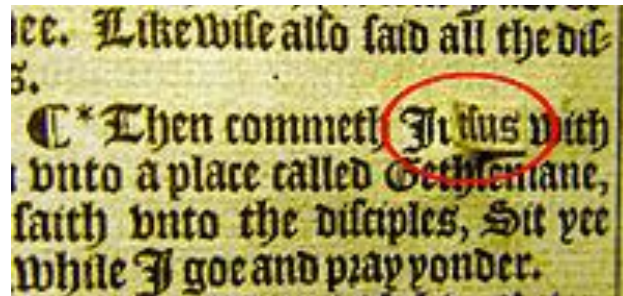
**וישב דויד במצד; על-כן קראו-לו עיר דויד.
ויבן העיר מסביב, מן-המלוא ועד-הסביב;**

**“And David dwelt in the stronghold; therefore they called it the city of David.
And he built the city round about, from Millo even roundabout (1 Ch 11:7-8).**

It seems that the Chronicler was not familiar with the topography of Jerusalem in David’s time. Furthermore, it appears that he did not fully understand the description of the city as it appeared in the Book of Samuel.

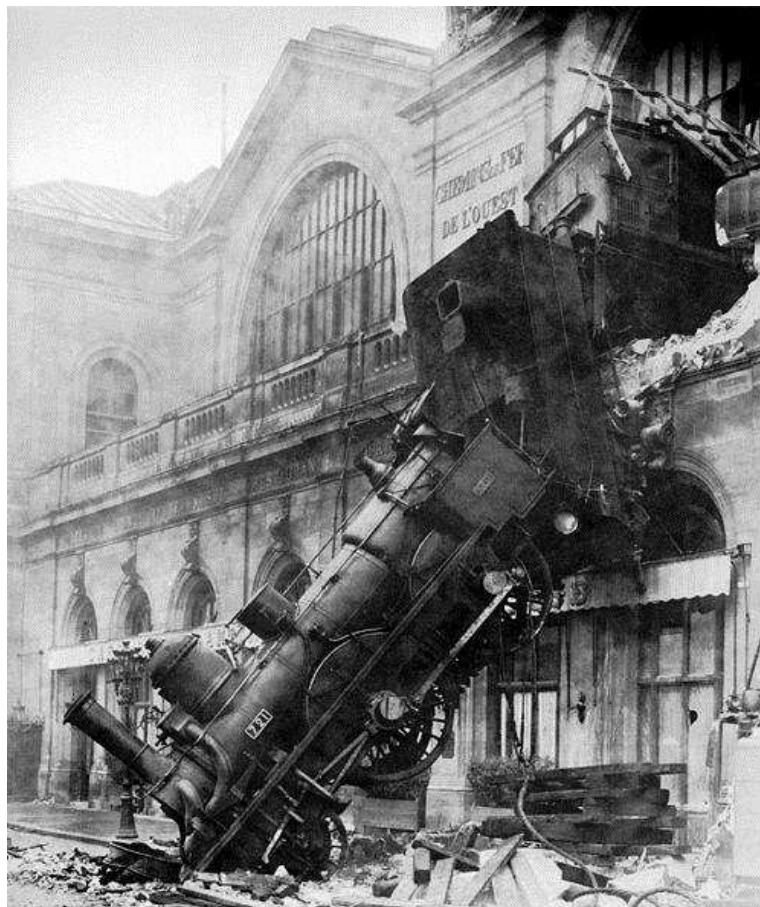
St. Augustine wrote: “Humanum fuit errare, diabolicum est per animositatem in errore manere” (Sermones 164, 14) - **“To err is human, but to persist in error out of pride is diabolical”.**

Prince Charles Maurice de Talleyrand-Périgord (1754–1838), not only survived, but was also a successful and central politician in the Ancient Regime, the French Revolution, the Napoleonic period, and the Restoration. He claimed as his own an old saying: “*La parole a été donnée à l’homme pour déguiser sa pensée*” (Speech was given to man to conceal his thoughts). This notion suggests that if errors were made by late biblical scribes, they may conceal the meaning of the original biblical texts, or even give them content not intended by the creators of these writings.



The Bible in St Mary's Church, [Totnes, Devon. UK](#). This edition (1613) is known as the "Judas' Bible" because in Matthew c26 v36 "Judas" appears instead of "Jesus". In this copy the mistake is corrected with a slip of paper pasted over the misprint.

A recent CBS Sunday Morning program's title was: "**Make no Mistake: To err is human,**" and we should remember that the biblical scribes were human.



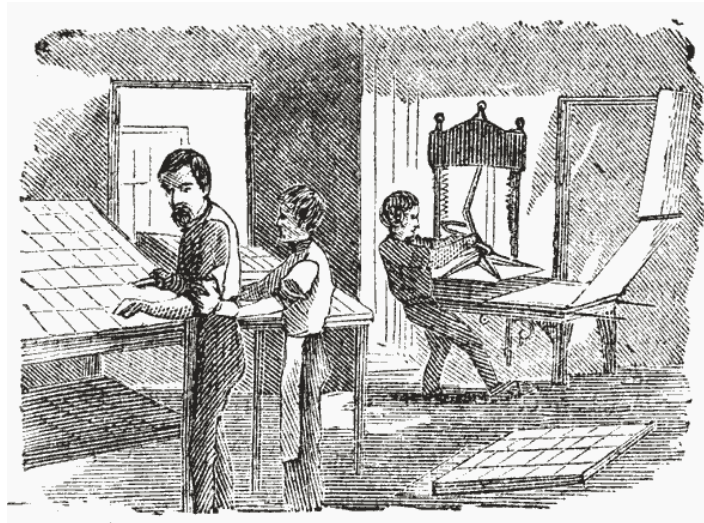
Train wreck at Montparnasse, Paris, 1895.



The USA postal stamp known as the Inverted Jenny first issued on May 10, 1918. The image of the Curtiss JN-4 airplane was accidentally printed upside-down.

It is estimated that even with the most advanced medical systems available, involuntary errors are responsible in the USA for more than 100.000 iatrogenic deaths a year.

The American president George Washington once said: "**To err is natural, to rectify error is glory.**"



A printing press from the nineteenth century

Samuel Langhorne Clemens (Mark Twain, 1835-1910) who at the age of twelve became a printer's apprentice and later a typesetter once said: "**Be careful about reading health books. You may die of a misprint.**"

It is quite certain that Twain did not typeset the Talmud, or even read it, but the Thanaitic Rabbi Ishmael in his counsel to the scribes expressed a similar advice:

**בני, הוי זהיר שמלאכתך מלאכת שמים היא , שמא תחסיר אות אחת או תתיר אות אחת,
נמצאת אתה מחריב את כל העולם כולו.**

“Be careful in your work, my son, for your work is the work of Heaven. Omit or add a single letter and you can destroy the whole world.” (Eruvin 13a).

Earlier, the Jewish historian Titus Flavius Josephus (c. 37 - 100 AD) wrote about the Bible:

“For during so many ages as have already passed, no one has been so bold as either to add anything to them, to take anything from them, or to make any change in them; but it has become natural to all Jews immediately, and from their very birth, to esteem these books to contain Divine doctrines” (Against Apion. Book 1, Sec. 8).

In the Book of Deuteronomy we read:

**ועתה ישראל שמע אל-החקים ואל-המשפטים אשר אנכי מלמד אתכם לעשות--למען תחיו
ובאתם וירשתם את-הארץ אשר יהוה אלהי אבותיכם נתן לכם.**

**לא תספו על-הדבר אשר אנכי מצוה אתכם, ולא תגרעו ממנו--לשמר את-מצות יהוה
אלהיכם, אשר אנכי מצוה אתכם.**

“And now, O Israel, hearken to the statutes and to the ordinances, which I teach you, to do them; that you may live, and go in and possess the land which YHWH, the God of your fathers, gives you.

You shall not add to the word which I command you, neither shall you diminish from it, that you may keep the commandments of YHWH your God which I command you” (Deu 4:1-2; see also: Deu 13:1).

Although it is clear that this directive relates to the content of the Law, it is not necessarily so when it comes to the form of the text. Furthermore, there are indications in the Hebrew version of the Bible that even prior to the 3rd century BC, the scribes inserted “corrections” into the biblical texts (for detail see chapter: Intentional variants).

Without pondering whether God did or did not deliver His words to men, it is obvious that the biblical texts that we have today are not the original ones but only copies of copies of the original manuscripts (and their translations). As there is no indication that the copying (and the translation) process was overseen by God, it is possible that some of the scribes erred.

Several texts appear in the Bible more than once (e.g. 2 Sam 8:1-18 ver. 1 Ch 18:1-17; 2 Sam 22:1-51 ver. Ps 18:1-51; 2 Ki 19:20-20:11 ver. Is 37:21-38:8; 2 Ki 24:18- 25:30 ver. Jer 52:1- 30; 1 Ch 8:28-38 ver. 1 Ch 9:34-44: For a complete list see: “Parallels in the Bible” by Abba Bendavid. Carta. Jerusalem 1972; M A Fishbane. Biblical interpretation in ancient Israel. Clarendon Press. 1985).

The comparison between parallel texts indicates that, in addition to typographical errors scribes made deliberate changes to the texts. The comparison between chapter eight of the Second Book of Samuel and chapter eighteen of the First Book of Chronicles indicates that the Chronicler had changed many details that appear in the Book of Samuel, including the names of people and towns.

The following is an example of intentional variations found in parallel texts:

In the 2nd Book of Samuel (22:44 - 49) we read:

ותפלטני מריבי עמי; תשמרני לראש גוים, עם לא-ידעתי יעבדני.
בני נכר יתכחשו-לי; לשמוע און ישמעו לי.
בני נכר יבלו; ויחרו ממסגרותם.
חי-יהוה וברוך צורי; וירם אלהי צור ישעי.
האל הנתן נקמת לי; ומריד עמים תחתני.
ומוציאי מאיבי; ומקמי, תרוממני, מאיש חמסים תצילני.

In the Book of Psalms (18:44 - 49) we find:

תפלטני מריבי-עם: תשימני לראש גוים; עם לא-ידעתי יעבדני.
לשמע און ישמעו לי; בני-נכר יכחשו-לי.
בני-נכר יבלו; ויחרו ממסגרותיהם.
חי-יהוה וברוך צורי; וירם אלוהי ישעי.
האל--הנותן נקמות לי; וידבר עמים תחתני.
מפלטי מאיבי: אף מן-קמי תרוממני; מאיש חמס תצילני.

Although it is likely that the Psalmist made some errors when he copied this narrative of the Book of Samuel (or vice versa), it is clear that several of the changes were made deliberately. These alterations apparently reflect the evolutionary variations in the Hebrew language that occurred between the time, when the Book of Samuel had been written, and the time of the Psalmist.

Almost unavoidably, the copying of a text by hand is associated with making spelling mistakes. As the Hebrew Bible was copied by hand many times prior to the production of the oldest known exemplars in existence (the Dead-Sea scrolls of the 3rd century BC - 1st century AD, and the Aleppo and Leningrad codices of the 10th -11th centuries AD), it is not unexpected that it is marred by misspelled words.

The number of errors in the Qumran biblical texts varied considerably. It is most likely that it relate to the individual skills of the scribes who wrote them. For example, while scroll 1QIs^b contains on average one correction for every 41 lines, the corresponding figure for scroll 1QIs^a is one correction for every four lines. (E. Tov. Corrections produced in the texts from the Judean desert. In: D.W. Parry and E. C. Ulrich (Eds.) The Provo International Conference on the Dead Sea Scrolls. Brill, 1999. Pp 232-263).

The accuracy of a copy depends in part on the quality of the equipment used and the skill and the health of the scribe.



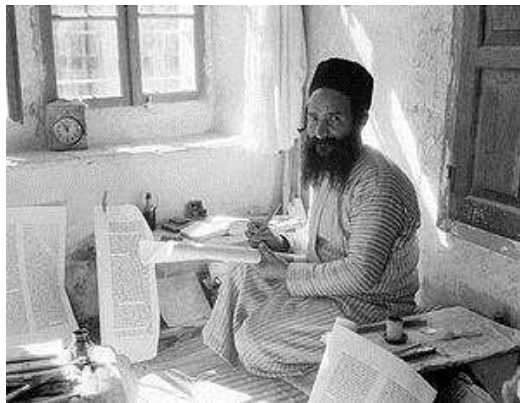
A Mesopotamian scribe (used Cuneiform script, mainly on clay tablets)



Egyptian scribe with a papyrus scroll (used Hieroglyphs signs)



Jean Mielot (15th century). A European scribe at work



Yemenite Jewish scribes - סופרי סתם in Jerusalem c. 1936

The earliest known Hebrew biblical writings (known as the “Dead Sea Scrolls”) were inscribed on parchments. There is almost no information on the process of their production, or the relationship between availability, quality and price. It is not known where they were produced, or by whom. However, it appears obvious that **the availability and quality of the parchments used by the biblical scribes affected the comprehension of the written text and therefore the process of later copying.**

There is no information on the necessary prerequisites of professional scribes in the biblical period. It is not even certain that men with visual and/or auditory impediments, or even dyslectics were barred from the profession.

If there were scribes who suffered from such limitations we could expect to find in the biblical text pattern recognition, speech perception, and order-type errors. We will demonstrate in the following pages that all these types of errors are found in the Massoretic version of the Bible.

Apel, Masterson, and Niessen, indicated that: **“Correct spelling is a skill that depends on the individual’s phonological awareness, knowledge of orthography, vocabulary, morphological and semantic relationships, and mental orthographic images.”** (K. Apel, J.J. Masterson, and N.L. Niessen: Spelling assessment frameworks. In: A Stone, ER Silliman, B Ehren, and K Apel Eds. Handbook of Language and Literacy: Development and Disorder. Guilford Press. NY. 2004. pp. 644-660).

In the middle of the 17th century AD, new Torah scrolls were written in Kaifeng, China for its Jewish community. It is believed that the hundreds of scribal errors in each of them are due to the decrease in knowledge of the Hebrew language. It is unlikely that in Biblical times there were scribes who did not master the Hebrew language. However, it is possible that when the scribes copied older Hebrew texts containing words and phrases that were no longer in current use and therefore unknown to them, they sometimes may have miscopied them.

It was shown by Damerau that **even when the correct spelling of an English word is known to an average man, typographic errors can occur** when he copies a text. **Single letter insertion, deletion, or substitution, and transposition of two adjacent letters, account for 80 percent of such errors.** The more common among these errors are single letter deletion and substitution (FJ Damerau. A technique for computer detection and correction of spelling errors. Commun ACM 7:171-177, 1964).

In his book: The textual criticism of the Bible, Prof Emanuel Tov lists several types of changes/errors that were associated with the scribal work of copying the Hebrew Bible. Among the causes of “unintentional variants” Tov mentions: **deletions, additions, changes in order, exchanges between letters that have similar shape or similar sound, and mis-division to words** (E. Tov: The Textual Criticism of the Bible: An Introduction. Mosad Bialik, Jerusalem 1997. 2nd Edition. In Hebrew. pp 186-214).

It is evident from the Septuagint that the Greek translators were aware of most, if not all, the types of scribal errors found in the Hebrew biblical texts which they used for the translation (Vorlage). I assume that this awareness was a reflection of their familiarity with the new

knowledge about the linguistic principals of the Greek language that was obtained in the preceding era. The comparison between the extant texts indicates that the translators glossed or outright corrected many of what they assumed to be scribal errors. It is hard to believe that the Jewish-Greek translators allowed themselves to correct such “scribal errors” unless they knew that the scribes of the Hebrew Bible themselves were involved in such a practice.

It was indicated by Prof Tov that there are fifteen instances in the Massoretic manuscripts of the Bible where dots are found above letters. Ten of these *puncta extraordinaria* appear in the Pentateuch (Gen 16:5; 18:9; 19:33; 33:4; 37:12; Num 3:39; 9:10; 21:30; 29:15; Deu 15), one in the Book of Samuel (2 Sam10:20), one in Isaiah (Is 44:9), two in the Book of Ezekiel (41:20; 46:22), and one in the Book of Psalms (27:13; with additional dot under the letter). For example:

וראו את מכות הארץ ההוא ואת תולאיה אשר
זלה יהיה בה גפרית ומלח שרפה כל ארצה
לא תזרע ולא תצמוח ולא יעלה בה כל עשב
כמהפכת סדם ועמרה אדמה וצביים אשר הפך
יהיה באפו ובזמיתו ואמרו כל הגוים על מה עשה
יהיה ככה לארץ הזאת מה זרי האף הגדול הזה
ואמרו על אשר עזבו את ברית יהיה אלהי אבתם
אשר כרת עמם בהוציאו אתם מארץ מצרים
ויכלו ויעבדו אלהים אחרים וישתחוו להם
אלהים אשר לא ידעום ולא זלזל להם ויזר אף
יהיה בארץ ההוא להביא עליה את כל הקללה
הכתובה בספר הזה ויתשם יהיה מעל אדמתם
באף ובזמיה ובקצף גדול וישלכם אל ארץ
אחרת כיום הזה הנסתרת ליהיה אלהינו והנצל
לנו ולבנינו עד עולם לעשות את כל דברי
התורה הזאת והיה כי יבאו
עליך כל הדברים האלה הברכה והקללה אשר
נתתי לפניך והשבת אל לבבך בכל הגוים אשר
הדיחך יהיה אלהיך שמה ושבת עד יהיה אלהיך
ושמעית בקולו ככל אשר אנכי מצוך היום אתה
ובניך בכל לבבך ובכל צפשיך ושב יהיה אלהיך
את שבו ונתך ורומך ושב וקבצך מכל העמים
אשר הפיצך יהיה אלהיך שמה אם יהיה גדוהך
בקצה השמים משם יקבצך יהיה אלהיך ומשם
יקוץ והביאך יהיה אלהיך אל הארץ אשר ירשו
אבותיך וירשתה ויהיטבך והרבך מאבותיך ומל
יהיה אלהיך את לבבך ואת לבב זרעך לאהבה
את יהיה אלהיך בכל לבבך ובכל צפשיך כלמיעך
וזייך ונתן יהיה אלהיך את כל האלות האלה על
איבך ועל שצאך אשר רדפוך ואתה תשוב
ושמעית בקול יהיה ועשית את כל מצותיו אשר
אנכי מצוך היום והתירך יהיה אלהיך בכל מעשה
ידך בפרי בטן ובפרי בהמתך ובפרי אדמתך
לטובה כי ישוב יהיה לשוש עליך לשוב כאשר
שש על אבותיך כי תשמע בקול יהיה אלהיך
לשמר מצותיו וזקתיו הכתובה בספר התורה
הזה כי תשוב אל יהיה אלהיך בכל לבבך ובכל
צפשיך כי המצוה הזאת אשר
אנכי מצוך היום לא נפלאה הוא ממך ולא רחוקה
הוא לא בשמים הוא כאמר מי יעלה לנו השמימה
ויקוזה לנו וישמענו אתה ונעשה וכל מעבר לים
הוא כאמר מי יעבר לנו אל עבר הים ויקוזה לנו

Already the Talmudic sages speculated that these dots marked letters that should not have appeared in the biblical texts. The surveying of the majority of the biblical Dead Sea scrolls led Tov to conclude that the most common procedure for deleting letters that were considered by scribes as superfluous, was by adding “cancellation dots.” (E. Tov. Corrections produced in the texts from the Judean desert. In: D.W. Parry and E. C. Ulrich, Eds. The Provo International Conference on the Dead Sea Scrolls. Brill. 1999. Pp 232-263).

The contrary process of adding of single letters into a written biblical text by a scribe may have involved an intermediate stage of “hanging letters” which later might be further changed to regular letters. Here is an example:

In the Massoretic version of the Book of Judges we read:

ויהונתן בן-גרשם בן-מֶשֶׁה הוא ובניו, היו כהנים לשבט הדני, עד-יום גלות הארץ.

“And Jonathan, the son of Gershom, the son of Manasseh, he and his sons were priests to the tribe of the Danites until the day of the captivity of the land” (Jud 18:30).

It appears odd that this priest who was of the Levite tribe (Jud 17:7-13; 18:3, 15-20) would have a grandfather named Manasseh. In the codex Alexandrinus we find here: “son of Moyses” and it appears that the writer of this Greek text assumed that the letter נ (n) in מֶשֶׁה - “Manasseh” is superfluous, or that it was lacking in his Vorlage. In the Massoretic version of the Bible the נ (n) letter here is a “hanging letter” suggesting that it was an insertion into the text, probably introduced by a late scribe who wanted to indicate that this person was not related to Gershom son of Moses.

“Hanging letters” are also found in the Dead-Sea scrolls. For example in 4Q158 Fragment 1-2, line 6 (Gen 32:29) we read:

[ו]ע[ם] אנשים ותוכל וישׁל י[ע]קוב [ו]יאמ[ר] הגי[ד] לִי [מ]ה שמכה ויאמר למה זה תשאל לשמי



In the Book of Exodus we read:

אם-לא ימצא הגנב, ונקרב בעל-הבית אל-האלהים: אם-לא שלח ידו במלאכת רעהו.
“If the thief be not found, then the master of the house shall come near to God, to see whether he have not put his hand to his neighbor's goods” (Ex 22:7).

In 4Q158 Fragment 10-12, line 9 we read:

[אם לוא ימצא הגנב ונקרב בעל הבית לפני האלוהים אם לוא ילח ידו במלאכת רעהו]

Based on the comparison with the Massoretic version of the Book of Exodus M. M. Zahn concluded that **ילח** (*yalakh*) in this Dead Sea scroll is most likely a letter-substitution error of **שלח** (*shalakh*) - “put” (Molly M. Zahn. The forms and methods of early Jewish reworking of the Pentateuch in light of 4Q158. A Dissertation. Notre Dame, Indiana. 2009. P 108).

In the Qumran Hodayot scroll (1QH^a) X 6 we find the word **אכשיל** (*achshil*) where the letter **כ** is marked by horizontal lines above and below it. Prof Tov suggested that these lines are a scribal indication that this word is an order-type error of the word **אשכיל** (*askil*) - “I will become knowledgeable.”

For over 500 years military historians attributed the discovery of gunpowder to a German Franciscan monk from Freiburg - Der Schwarzer Berthold. The source of this information was supposed to be an entry made under the year 1313 in the records of the city of Ghent: “**In this year the use of bussen (cannon) was discovered in Germany by a monk.**” In 1923 the British military historian Sir Charles Oman searched the Ghent's archive and found that this entry appeared not in the text but as a marginal note. Furthermore, the year mentioned was MCCCXCIII (1393) and not MCCCXIII (1313). (C.W.C. Oman. The art of war in the Middle-Ages. A.D. 378-1485. 2nd Ed. Rev & Enl. Methun & Co. London 1924).

In the Book of Chronicles we find the following:

עזר, ישבקשה מלותי, הותיר מחזיאת.
“Ezer, Joshbekashah, Mallothi, Hothir, Mahazioth” (1 Ch 25:4).

The conventional interpretation assumes that these are the names of some of the sons of Heman. However, a free translation of these words could mean: “Help; there is a request from Lothi. Permission was given by Khaziat.” It is possible that these words and even some of the preceding ones (e.g. **גדלתי ורממתי** - *gidalti veromamti*) appeared first as marginal notes (that probably were not even related to the text itself), and were later incorporated into the main text by an unscrupulous scribe.

In the Book of Nehemiah we read:

ואחיו שמעיה ועזראל מללי גללי מעי
“And his brethren, Shemaiah, and Azarel, Milalai, Gilalai, Maai” (Neh 12:36).

However, when we read about: **גללי צאת האדם** - “**dung that comes out of man**” (Eze 4:12), the meaning of verse Neh 12:36 could be viewed differently and may represent some non-biblical material that somehow found its way into the text.



Qumran Isaiah scroll. Photographed by John C. Trever in 1948. Is 40:2-28



Qumran Isaiah scroll. Photographed by John C. Trever in 1948. Is 34:1-36:2

Parchment unlike papyrus does not lend itself well to erasing written material. Therefore, when a scribe realized that he skipped a word, he apparently looked for a proper place in the text for adding it. Here is an example:

In the Book of Leviticus we read:

**ואת-הכוס ואת-השלך, ואת-הינשוף.
ואת-התנשמת ואת-הקאת, ואת-הרחם.
“And the little owl, and the cormorant, and the great owl;
And the horned owl, and the pelican, and the carrion-vulture” (Lev 11:17-18).**

Yet in the Book of Deuteronomy we find:

**את-הכוס ואת-הינשוף, והתנשמת.
והקאת ואת-הרחמה, ואת-השלך.
“The little owl, and the great owl, and the horned owl;
And the pelican, and the carrion-vulture, and the cormorant” (Deu 14:16-17).**

We read in the book of Psalms:

**חציך שנונים : עמים תחתיד יפלו ; בלב אויבי המלך.
“Your arrows are sharp--the peoples fall under you--[they sink] into the heart of the king's
enemies” (Ps 45:6).**

However, it is highly likely that originally this verse appeared as:

**חציך שנונים בלב אויבי המלך : עמים תחתיד יפלו.
“Your arrows are sharp [they sink] into the heart of the king's enemies, the peoples fall under
you.”**

The simplest and crudest mistakes that are caused by negligent scribes are haplography (omission) and dittography (duplication) of letters, words or even sentences.

In the Book of Exodus we read:

**את-חג המצות תשמר--שבעת ימים תאכל מצות אשר צויתך, למועד חדש האביב : כי בחדש
האביב יצאת ממצרים.
“The feast of unleavened bread shall you keep. Seven days shall eat unleavened bread, as I
commanded you, at the time appointed in the month Abib, for in the month Abib you came
out from Egypt” (Ex 34:18; see also: Ex 23:15; Lev 23:6; Deu 16:16; Ezr 6:22; 2 Ch 8:13;
30:13, 21; 35:17).**

Yet in the same book we read:

**ושמרתם את-[] המצות, כי בעצם היום הזה הוצאתי את-צבאותיכם מארץ מצרים ; ושמרתם
את-היום הזה לדורותיכם--חקת עולם.
“And you shall observe the feast of unleavened bread; for in this selfsame day have I
brought your hosts out of the land of Egypt; therefore shall you observe this day
throughout your generations by an ordinance forever” (Ex 12:17).**

The English (but not the Greek) translation indicates that the translator believed that the word חג (*khag*) - “feast” is missing in verse 12:17 of the Book of Exodus.

In the Book of Jeremiah a certain verse appears twice:

לא-כאלה חלק יעקב, כי-יוצר הכל הוא, וישראל שבט נחלתו: יהוה צבאות שמו.

“Not like these is the portion of Jacob; for He is the former of all things, and Israel is the tribe of His inheritance; *YHWH* of hosts is His name” (Jer 10:16).

לא-כאלה חלק יעקב, כי-יוצר הכל הוא—[] ושבט נחלתו: יהוה צבאות שמו.

“The portion of Jacob is not like these; for He is the former of all things, and [] is the tribe of His inheritance; *YHWH* of hosts is His name” (Jer 51:19).

It is apparent the word **ישראל** - “Israel” was omitted in verse Jer 51:19.

It has long been noticed that in the Massoretic version of the Bible, a verse beginning with the letter נ (n) is not present in the acrostic Psalm 145 (unlike Ps 119). However, such a verse appears in the Septuagint (LXX) and similarly is found in the Qumran’s scroll of Psalms.

We read in the Book of Jeremiah:

אַל-יִדְרֹךְ יִדְרֹךְ () הַדֶּרֶךְ קִשְׁתּוֹ, וְאַל-יִתְעַל בְּסִרְיָנוּ; וְאַל-תַּחְמְלוּ, אֶל-בַּחֲרִיקָה--הַחֲרִימוּ, כָּל-צִבְאָה.

“Let the archer bend his bow against her, and let him lift himself up against her in his coat of mail; and spare you not her young men, destroy you utterly all her host” (Jer 51:3).

The duplication here of the word **יִדְרֹךְ** (*idroch*) - “bend” was already noticed by the Massoretic editor.

In the Book of Haggai we read:

כֹּה אָמַר יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת, לֵאמֹר: הָעַם הַזֶּה אָמְרוּ, לֹא עַתָּה-בָּא עַת-בֵּית יְהוָה לְהַבְנוֹת.

“Thus said *YHWH* of hosts, saying: This people say: The time is not come, the time that *YHWH*’s house should be built” (Hag 1:2).

The Greeks wrote here:

“the time has not come to build the Lord’s house.”

The understanding of the Greek translator suggests that he believed that the first **עַת** (*e’t*) is superfluous.

In the Book of Jeremiah verses 6:14-15, appear also as verses 8:11-12. However, in the Septuagint this dittography was omitted.

As was pointed by Guy Deutscher, the English language had been transformed in the last millennium to such a degree that the writing of Aelfric, Abbot of Eynsham (c. 955 – c. 1010) are largely incomprehensible to the current speakers of the same language. Deutscher indicated that this is not a peculiar feature of the English language but that all languages (except for dead ones) change all the time. The **changes, driven mainly by economy, expressiveness, and analogy, result in a constant change in the sounds, meaning of words and even structures of every language. The changing reality and the exposure to words and expressions of speakers of other languages are contributing factors but are not the major causes for the instability of**

the spoken language. (G. Deutscher. The unfolding of language: The evolution of Mankind's greatest invention. Arrow Books. 2006).

The following are examples for some of the more recent secondary linguistic transformations:

Encyclopaedia Britannica describes the changes over time in the meaning of the term “encyclopedia.” The current understanding of “encyclopedia” is very different from what the Greeks called: “*en gyglios paidea* – a circle of learning.”



How many young men are currently familiar with expression: “At the top (or bottom) of the hour”?



Why would you say these days: “dial number 123-4545,” when you actually mean: “press the phone’s numbered buttons 123-4545.”



Presently, not many young men understand the phrase: “He speaks like a broken record.”

As the biblical texts were written over several hundred years they could not have escaped this process. The meaning of some biblical words must have changed over time, and the understanding of other words that had long ago fallen out of use was lost. Here are few examples:

In the Book of Exodus we hear Pharaoh telling Moses and Aaron:

העתירו אל-יהוה, ויסר הצפרדעים ממני ומעמי

“Entreat YHWH, that He take away the frogs from me, and from my people” (Ex 8:4; see also: Ex 8:4, 5, 24, 25, 26; 9:28; 10:17, 18; Jud 13:8; Eze 35:13; Job 22:27; 33:26).

Yet in the Book of Samuel we find:

ויעתר יהוה לארץ, ותעצר המגפה מעל ישראל

“So YHWH responded favorably to the land, and the plague was stayed from Israel” (2 Sam 24:25; see also: 2 Sam 21:14; Is 19:22; Eze 8:23; 1 Ch 5:20).

In the Book of Numbers we read:

כל-ימי נדר נזרו, תער לא-יעבר על-ראשו: עד-מלאת הימם אשר-יזיר ליהוה, קדש יהיה-- גדל פרע שער ראשו

“All the days of his vow of Naziriteship there shall no razor come upon his head; until the days be fulfilled, in which he consecrates himself to YHWH, he shall be holy, he shall let the locks of the hair of his head grow long” (Num 6:5; see also 8:7; Is 7:20; Jer 36:23; Eze 5:1; Ps 52:4).

Yet in the Book of Samuel we find:

את-ראשו; וירץ דוד ויעמד אל-הפלשתי ויקח את-חרבו וישלפה מתערה, וימתתהו ויכרת-בה

“And David ran, and stood over the Philistine, and took his sword, and drew it out of the sheath thereof, and slew him, and cut off his head therewith” (1 Sam 17:51; see also: 2 Sam 20:8; Jer 47:6; Eze 21:8, 9, 10, 35).

In the Book of Deuteronomy we read:

לא-תטע לך אשרה, כל-עץ: אצל מזבח יהוה אלהיך--אשר תעשה-לך.

“You shall not plant you an Asherah of any kind of tree beside the altar of YHWH your God, which you shall make you” (Deu 16:21).

כי-אם-כה תעשו להם--מזבחתיהם תתצו, ומצבתם תשברו; ואשירהם תגדעו, ופסיליהם תשרפון באש.

“But thus shall you deal with them: you shall break down their altars, and dash in pieces their pillars, and hew down their Asherim, and burn their graven images with fire” (Deu 7:5; see also: 2 Ch 14:2; 31:1).

Similarly in the Book of Exodus we find:

כי את-מזבחתם תתצו, ואת-מצבתם תשברו; ואת-אשריו תכרתו.

“But you shall break down their altars, and dash in pieces their pillars, and you shall cut down their Asherim” (Ex 34:13; see also Jud 6:25-30; 2 Ki 18:4; 23:14).

These verses indicate that **אשרה** (*ashera*) is a type of a sacred tree that was often planted near an altar.

However, in the Book of Kings we also read:

ויבנו גם-המה להם במות ומצבות, ואשרים, על כל-גבעה גבהה, ותחת כל-עץ רענן.

“For they also built them high places, and pillars, and Asherim, on every high hill, and under every leafy tree” (1 Ki 14:23; see also 2 Ki 17:10; Jer 27:2).

The new portrayal of **אשרה** (*ashera*) being “built” “under every leafy tree,” is very different from its former description as a live tree. However, it is compatible with:

פסל האשרה “The graven image of Asherah” (2 Ki 21:7), that King Manasseh placed in the House of God in Jerusalem (2 Ki 21:7).

Although in the Septuagint (LXX) all the Asherah(s) words of these verses appear as “grove(s)” (except in Jer 17:2 which was omitted altogether), it appears that the meaning of this Hebrew word had changed over time.

If the changes in language are indeed driven mainly by economy, expressiveness, and analogy, while words adopted from other languages play only a secondary roll, then we should concentrate most of our efforts in searching for the evidence for such changes in the biblical text itself.

The impact of a text in general and of a religious one in particular, depends to a large extent on the ability of the readers to understand its content. The comprehension of the biblical texts, originally written almost exclusively with consonant letters, and without spaces between words, was vitally dependent on the familiarity of the readers with the correct pronunciation of the consonant-based words. If, for one reason or another (e.g. passage of time, decline in the use of the language), the readers no longer master the language of the written text, and do not know the correct pronunciation, the need for reading helping devices becomes essential. There is evidence that as early as the 6th century BC (and probably even earlier) **אימות קריאה** - *matres lectionis* (Latin: mothers of reading) - vowel letters were inserted into the biblical texts, and such additions were carried out over many centuries.

Diacritic marks for distinguishing between homographic words (or for pronouncing the proper accent) are found in many languages. Following the introduction of diacritic marks in Greek (3rd century BC), and Christian Aramaic (3rd century AD) texts, the Jews of Mesopotamia developed their own system of diacritical signs in the 7th century AD (or even earlier). In fact, it appears that at this period the Jews of the Middle East developed several independent systems of diacritic marks (נִקּוּד – *niqud*). As can be witnessed from the Leningrad and Aleppo codices, the diacritic system developed by the Ben-Asher family in Tiberias became the most accepted one. Yet later, for further improvement of the reading, spaces between the words were also introduced into the biblical texts. However, we have to remember that these alterations represent the opinions of their introducers and that sometimes they are incorrect. For example: in the Book of Exodus we read:

וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת-הַמִּצּוֹת, כִּי בַעֲצָם הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה הוֹצֵאתִי אֶת-עַבְדֹּתֵיכֶם מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרָיִם; וּשְׁמַרְתֶּם אֶת-הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה לְדֹרֹתֵיכֶם--חֻקַּת עוֹלָם.

“And you shall observe the [feast of] unleavened bread; for in this selfsame day have I brought your hosts out of the land of Egypt; therefore shall you observe this day throughout your generations by an ordinance forever” (Ex 12:17).

Yet in the Septuagint the reading is: “commandment” and it appears that the Greek translator reading here is מִצְוֹת (*mitzvot*) rather than מַצּוֹת (*matzot*).

In the Book of Ezekiel we read:

גַּם-הֵם אָתּוּ יֵרְדוּ שָׂאוֹלָה--אֶל-חֲלִי-חֶרֶב; וְזָרְעוּ יֵשְׁבוּ בְּצִלוֹ, בְּתוֹךְ גּוֹיִם.

“They also went down into the nether-world with him to them that are slain by the sword; yea, [they that were in] his arm, that dwelt under his shadow in the midst of the nations” (Eze 31:17).

The Greek translator wrote here: “and his offspring” which indicates that his reading here was as it appears in the Book of Genesis:

וְזָרְעוּ יִהְיֶה מְלֶאכֶת-הַגּוֹיִם

“and his seed shall become a multitude of nations” (Gen 48:19).

For many Jews whose Hebrew was wanting, even these improvements were not a remedy and the need for translations of the Hebrew Bible became indispensable.

“But how shall men meditate in that which they cannot understand; How shall they understand that which is kept close in an unknown tongue?” (The Translators to the Reader. Miles Smith, Bishop of Gloucester 1554-1624). The Bible was translated to some 450 different languages, yet it is odd that in most, if not all, of these versions of the Bible the translators do not admit that they could not comprehend at least some of the book’s words. However, it should be noted that in the Septuagint the Greek translators used the word “things” multiple times apparently for Hebrew words that they could not comprehend. In addition, it seems that on occasion, when the Greek translators could not figure out the meaning of a Hebrew expression they disregarded its presence.

Not surprisingly, the Hebrew version of the Bible is the major source of the Modern Hebrew language, but it is not widely known that the translations of the Bible to German and English also had important impacts on the evolution of these languages.



Codex Vaticanus

Bibles in Greek:

Codex Vaticanus (4th century AD)

Codex Alexandrinus (5th century AD)

There are some earlier incomplete texts such as fragments of Leviticus and Deuteronomy (Rahlfs nos. 801, 819, and 957)

The earliest existing complete texts of the Greek translations of the Bible (Codex Vaticanus and Codex Alexandrinus) are based on the “combined column” of Origen’s Hexapla written in the 2nd century AD. Origen (Adamantius Origenes, born in Alexandria c. 185 AD, died in Tyre c. 254 AD), a theologian of the early Greek Church, compiled an Old Testament Hexapla, a six-column comparison of the Hebrew, Greek transliteration of the Hebrew (Secunda), three Greek translations (Aquila, Symmachus, Theodotion), and “a combined text.” Only fragments of the Hexapla survived, but it appears that the existing complete Greek texts of the 4th - 5th centuries AD adhere to a great extent to Origen’s “combined text.”

Bible in Latin:

Vulgate (St. Jerome, 405 AD)

Bibles in English:

1. Tyndale's (1525-1530)
2. Coverdale's (1535)
3. Matthew's (1537)
4. The Great Bible (1539)
5. Geneva Bible (1560)
6. Bishops' (1568)
7. Reims-Douai Version (1610)
8. King James Version (1611)
9. Revised Standard Version (1885)
10. American Standard Version (1901)
11. Jewish Publication Society (JPS 1917; last rev 1999)
12. New American Standard Bible (1971)
13. New KJV
14. Webster's
15. Young's T
16. Darby T
17. New Living T
18. New International Version

The Septuagint codices of the 4th century AD are also copies of copies of the original manuscript of the Greek translators (3rd-1st centuries BC), and as was pointed out by Prof. Henry S. Gehman (a Minister of the Reformed Church) they contain many scribal errors (H. S. Gehman. Some types of errors of transmission in the LXX. *Vetus Testamentum*. 3:397-400. 1953). Furthermore, there is evidence that for various reasons, the translators themselves repeatedly misread the Hebrew texts (A. Gelston. Some Hebrew misreading in the Septuagint of Amos. *Vetus Testamentum* 52:493-500. 2002).

As was shown by Tov, **already in the 3rd century BC the scholars that translated the Hebrew Bible to Greek did not comprehend many biblical words. Frequently they have guessed the meaning of such words by their recurring pattern, parallelism in form, root letters, or the general content of the text. In at least 77 cases they apparently had not even a clue and just transliterated in Greek the Hebrew words** (E. Tov. *The Greek and Hebrew Bible: Collected essays on the Septuagint*. Brill, Leiden. 1999. pp 203-218). Here are several examples:

In the Book of Samuel we hear Jonathan telling David:

ואני, שלשת החצים צדה אורה, לשלח-לי למטרה.

“And I will shoot three arrows to the side-ward, as though I shot at a mark”
(1 Sam 20:20).

The Greek translator wrote here: “into the amattari.” It appears that unlike the Greek translators of the Books of Job and Lamentations, the translator of the Book of Samuel did not know the meaning of the Hebrew word **מטרה** (*matarah*) - “a target” and he therefore just transliterated it.

We read in the Book of Kings:

**ותפל אש-יהוה ותאכל את-העלה ואת-העצים, ואת-האבנים, ואת-העפר; ואת-המים אשר-
בתעלה לחכה.**

“Then the fire of YHWH fell, and consumed the burnt-offering, and the wood, and the stones, and the dust, and licked up the water that was in the trench” (1 Ki 18:38).

The Greek translators wrote here:

“And fire from the Lord fell from heaven and consumed the whole burnt offering and the firewood and the water that was in the thaala, and the stones, and the fire licked up the dust.”

It appears that Greeks transliterated the Hebrew word meaning “trench” - **תעלה** (*tea'lah*) as “thaala.” On the other hand their (and the English after them) translation of **לחכה** (*likhechah*) here (and also in: Num 22:4; Is 49:23; Mic 7:17; Ps 72:9) as “licked up” suggests that they assumed that **לחכה** (*likhechah*) is a variant of **לקקה** (*liqeqah*) that indeed means: “lick up” (Jud 7:6, 7; 1 Ki 21:19; 22:38). However, the verb **לחכה** (*likhechah*) is related to the noun **חך** (*khech*) - “throat” (Eze 3:26; Hos 8:1; Ps 119:103; 137:6; Pro 8:7; 24:13; Job 6:30; 20:13; 29:10; 31:30; 33:2; Can 2:3; 5:16; 7:10; Thr 4:4), and therefore should be comprehended as “swallowed.”

In the Book of Jeremiah we read the enigmatic verse:

קראו שם פרעה מלך-מצרים שאון העביר המועד.

“They cried there: Pharaoh King of Egypt is but a noise; he has let the appointed time pass by” Jer 46:17).

In the Septuagint this verse appears as:

“Call the name of Pharaoh Nechao, king of Egypt, saon-esbi-emoed.”

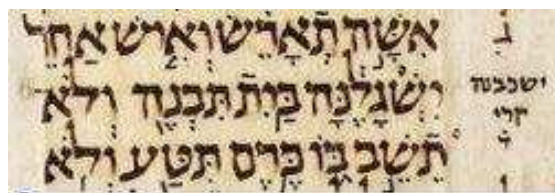
It is clear that the Greek translators did not comprehend the Hebrew version of this verse, and therefore just transliterated some of its words.

As indicated above, transliteration was carried out by the Greek translators for Hebrew words that they did not know their meaning. However, such a process is frequently associated with errors. For example, the Chronicler wrote: **והדברים עתיקים** - “**And the records are ancient**” (1 Ch 4:22). The Greeks wrote here: “Habederin Athoukiin” instead of: “*vehadvarim a'thiqim*.”

In the Book of Samuel we find the expression: **וענתך תרבני** - “**And Your condescension had made me great**” (2 Sam 22:36). In the LXX it appears as: “And your answer made me increase.” Yet in a copy of this verse found in the Book of Psalms this phrase was translated to Greek as: “And Your instruction set me straight completely” (Ps 18:36).

Eusebius Hieronymus (St. Jerome c.347-420 AD), the author of the Latin version of the Bible (Vulgate), said that the early Greek translators of the Bible (3rd -1st centuries BC) were interpreters and not Prophets. As learned men they did many good things, but sometimes, as men they stumbled and fell.

Correcting marginal notes are not found in the Qumran biblical texts, but it is possible that in other historic periods scribe's “corrections” did appear first as marginal notes, and only later were incorporated into the text.



Aleppo Codex. Deuteronomy 28:30

In this section of the Aleppo codex, a correcting note appears in smaller letters in the right margin. However, as shown below in a modern version of this verse, the marginal note appears (in brackets) inside the text.

אֶשֶׁה תְּאֲרִישׁ, וְאִישׁ אַחֲרַי
יִשְׁגְּלֶנָה (יִשְׁכַּבְנָה) -- בֵּית תְּבִנָּה, וְלֹא-
תֵשֵׁב בּוֹ; כָּרֶם תִּטֵּעַ, וְלֹא

The marginal notes were discussed in the Talmud. Although the sages mention notes which appear in the Books of the Prophets and Writings, there is no mention about the appearance of such notes in the Pentateuch. It should also be said that such notes do not appear in the current hand-written Torah scrolls.

It is not known at which historic period “official marginal notes” (*glossa*) begun to appear in the Hebrew biblical text, nor who made them. It is likely that the process of adding marginal notes occurred over extended period of time by scribes who believed that they encountered errors in the older texts. Rather than admitting that the sacred biblical text contains errors it was stated that the marginal notes are only about the “correct vocalization” or **כְּתִיב וקרי** - “written and read” forms.

The distribution of the marginal notes is not even. While in some biblical books they are totally lacking, in others we sometimes find a heavily corrected verse such as:

אכלנו (אֶכְלֵנִי) הממנו (הַמִּמְנִי), נְבוּכַדְרֶאצַּר מֶלֶךְ בָּבֶל, הִצִּיגְנִי (הַצִּיגְנִי) כְּלִי רִיק, בִּלְעֵנוּ (בִּלְעֵנִי) פִּתְיָן מִלֵּא כְּרֵשׁוֹ מַעְדָּנִי; הִדִּיחֵנִי (הִדִּיחְנִי).

“Nebuchadrezzar the king of Babylon had devoured me, he had crushed me, he had set me down as an empty vessel, he had swallowed me up like a dragon, he had filled his maw with my delicacies; he had washed me clean” (Jer 51:34).

מספר הערות הקרי בספרי המקרא			
ספר	מספר הערות קרי	מספר מילים	אחוז הערות הקרי
סה"כ תורה	32	79,847	0.0401%
סה"כ נביאים	559	141,414	0.3953%
סה"כ כתובים	463	83,640	0.5536%

In the Pentateuch there are only 32 marginal notes. The marginal notes are much more prevalent in the Books of the Prophets and Writings. Arnold Ehrlich suggested that due to the fact that the Pentateuch was studied more intensely than the rest of the Hebrew Bible, it currently contains fewer copying and other errors (Arnold B Ehrlich. Mikra ki-pheshuto. H M Orlinsky edition. Ktav Publishing House. New York. 1969. P. 7. In Hebrew).

The incidence of marginal notes in the Aramaic portions of the Bible (for 2.6% of the words) is significantly higher than their occurrence in the Hebrew parts of the Bible (for 0.3% of the words). This difference may suggest that the scribes that made these marginal notes were more proficient in Aramaic than in Hebrew, or signify a lower level of reverence of the biblical Aramaic texts.

The proportion of marginal notes per biblical book is also a good indication of the degree of corruption of the text (Lamentations - 1.34%; Ruth - 0.9%; Proverbs - 0.77%; Nahum - 0.72%; Jer - 0.60%; Samuel - 0.51%). On the other hand, it is also possible that books with content that is hard to comprehend (e.g. Job) largely discouraged the scribes from inserting correcting marginal notes.

Many marginal notes are correct but few of them do not improve the text, but rather corrupt it. Here are few examples:

In the Book of Samuel we read:

וְאוֹלָם, חַי-יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל, אֲשֶׁר מְנַעֲנִי, מִהָרַע אֹתְךָ: כִּי לֹלֵי מִהֲרַתְּ, וּתְבֹאֲתִי (וּתְבֹאֲתִי) לְקִרְאָתִי--כִּי אִם-נוֹתֵר לְנֶכֶל עַד-אוֹר הַבֶּקֶר, מִשְׁתִּין בְּקִיר.

“For in very deed, as YHWH, the God of Israel, lives, who had witholden me from hurting you, except you had made haste and come to meet me, surely there had not been left to Nabal by the morning light so much as one male” (1 Sam 25:34).

The Massoretic editors recognized an error in the word **תְּבֹאֲתִי** (*thavothi*) but replaced it with **תְּבֹאֲתִי** (*thavoth*), which is also a mistake, rather than with **תְּבֹאֲתִי** (*thavoyi*; see also: Eze 16:7; Can 4:8; Ruth 3:17).

We also find in this book:

וַיֵּלֶךְ דָּוִד, וַיִּקַּח אֶת-עַצְמוֹת שָׁאוּל וְאֶת-עַצְמוֹת יְהוֹנָתָן בְּנוֹ, מֵאֵת, בְּעָלֵי יָבִישׁ גִּלְעָד-אֲשֶׁר גָּנְבוּ אֹתָם מִיָּרֵחַ בֵּית-שָׁן, אֲשֶׁר תְּלוּם (תְּלָאוּם) שָׁם הַפְּלִשְׁתִּים (שָׁמָּה פְּלִשְׁתִּים), בְּיוֹם הַכּוֹת פְּלִשְׁתִּים אֶת-שָׁאוּל, בְּגִלְבֹּעַ.

“And David went and took the bones of Saul and the bones of Jonathan his son from the men of Jabesh-gilead, who had stolen them from the broad place of Beth-shan, where the Philistines had hanged them, in the day that the Philistines slew Saul in Gilboa” (2 Sam 21:12).

The Hebrew word **תְּלוּם** (*thalum*) meaning: “had hanged them” is properly spelled (see: Jos 10:26), while the “marginal note” here is an error.

When words or terms are transferred from one language to another, changes may occur.

In 1747 Johan Gottschalk Wallerius, a Swedish chemist and mineralogist, named a very common mineral as **feltspat**, meaning in Swedish “feldspar” (Tectosilicate minerals which make up as much as 60% of the Earth’s crust). In the German language the name appears as “**feldspat**,” and the British changed it to “**felspar**.”

The Latin word “curtus” is the same as the French “court” the English “short” the Old German “scurz” the Modern German “kurz” which fortuitously contains the same phonemes (but in different order of the Hebrew קצר (*qtsr*). However, this word demonstrates the exchanges between sibilants and the sound of Q (or K) and between Z (or TZ) and T, in particular when terms cross from one language to another.

In the Book of Judges the name שמשון (*shimshon*) appears 38 times. In the English version of the Bible it appears as “Samson” and in the early Greek translation we find it as “Σαμψών” (Sampson).

The Greek word: “Marmaros” was transformed to the Latin “Marmor” then to the French: “Marbre” and from there to the English “Marble.”

On the Mediterranean coast, 26 miles north of Beirut was an ancient town that was named by the Phoenicians: “*gbl*.” It is mentioned in the Hebrew Bible as גבל (*geval* or *gebal*) - “**Gebal**” (Jos 13:5; 1 Ki 5:32; Eze 27:9). In the Greek Septuagint it is translated as Βυβλίων (Biblians). As this town exported to Greece Egyptian papyrus, it is not surprising to learn that in Greek papyrus was referred to as *Byblos*, the origin of the English word “Bible.”

In the Book of Genesis we read about Jacob’s sleep in a place named Luz:

וַיַּחֲלֶם, וְהִנֵּה סֹלָם מַצֵּב אֶרֶצָה וְרֹאשׁוֹ מֵגִיעַ הַשָּׁמַיְמָה;

“**And he dreamed, and behold a ladder set up on the earth, and the top of it reached to heaven**” (Gen 28:12).

As was indicated by Harold R. Cohen (1978), the expression here that contains the once appearing word סֹלָם (*sulam*) - “**ladder**” has parallels in Akkadian: “*simmelat shamami*” - “ladder to heaven” (STT I, 28:V;42; STT I, 28:VI;18). However, it seems that the transfer of this word from Akkadian to Hebrew was associated with an order-type error that turned *simmilatu* to סֹלָם (*sulam*).

There are Talmudic remarks suggesting that Aramaic translations of the Hebrew Bible were already written in the 5th- 4th century BC. However, if indeed there were such texts, they have not survived. On the other hand, a variant of the translation of the Pentateuch to Old Greek (Koine), made in the 3rd century BC, has endured (in the Septuagint; LXX).

It was indicated by Gehman that in the period when the Septuagint was created, the spoken Greek language was considerably different from the one found in the LXX. The main difference resulted from the many “Hebraisms” made by the translators. Such Hebraisms can be found in the Greek translation of the Pentateuch and more so in the rest of the biblical texts (H. S. Gehman. Hebraism of the Old Greek Version of Genesis. *Vetus Testamentum* 3:141-148. 1953).

Some of the early translators' efforts to adhere to the Hebrew text resulted in odd meanings. For example:

We read in the Book of Genesis:

אלה תולדת שם--שם בן-מאת שנה, ויולד את-ארפכשד: שנתים אחר המבול.
“These are the generations of Shem. Shem was a hundred years old, and begot Arpachshad two years after the flood” (Gen 11:10).

The Greek translators wrote: “Sam was the son of one hundred years.”

In the Book of Samuel we read:

ויאמר דוד אל-לבו, עתה אספה יום-אחד ביד-שאול; אין-לי טוב כי המלט אמלט אל-ארץ פלשתים, ונאש ממני שאול לבקשני עוד בכל-גבול ישראל, ונמלטתי מידו.
“And David said in his heart: I shall now be swept away one day by the hand of Saul; there is nothing better for me than that I should escape into the land of the Philistines; and Saul will despair of me, to seek me any more in all the borders of Israel; so shall I escape out of his hand” (1 Sam 27:1).

The Greek translator wrote here: “I shall now be added in one day.”

In the Book of Samuel we also read:

ויבא אוריה אליו; ושאל דוד לשלום יואב ולשלום העם, ולשלום המלחמה.
“And when Uriah was come to him, David asked of him how Joab did, and how the people fared, and how the war prospered” (2 Sam 11:7).

The Greek translators wrote here that David asked: “After the peace of the war.”

Sometimes, in particular when the biblical text relate to Egypt, the Greek translators gave their own understanding of the text. Here are two examples

After the defeat of the Egyptian army of King Pharaoh Neco II in the battle of Carchemish (605 BC), the Prophet Jeremiah wrote among other things:

הגידו במצרים והשמיעו במגדול, והשמיעו בנף ובתחפנחס; אמרו, התיצב והכן לך--כי-אכלה חרב סביבך
מדוע נסחף אביריך: לא עמד, כי יהוה הדפו.
“Declare you in Egypt, and announce in Migdol, and announce in Noph and in Tahpanhes; say you: Stand forth, and prepare you, for the sword had devoured round about you. Why is your strong one overthrown? He stood not, because *YHWH* did thrust him down” (Jer 46:14-15).

The Alexandrian Greek translator who apparently was acquainted with the Greco-Egyptian culture wrote here:

“Declare in Magdolos, and proclaim in Memphis, say: Set up and be ready, because a dagger devoured you yew.

Why has Apis fled? Your [choice] bull calf did not remain, because the Lord paralyzed him.”

In the Book of Genesis we read:

וַיֵּשְׁבֶת בְּאֶרֶץ-גֹּשֶׁן, וְהָיִיתָ קָרוֹב אֵלַי--אֶתָּה וּבְנֶיךָ וּבְנֵי בְנֶיךָ;

“And you shall dwell in the land of Goshen, and you shall be near to me, you, and your children, and your children's children” (Gen 45:10).

The Greek translators who apparently did not know about any place in Egypt having such a name, wrote: ἐν γῇ Γεσεμ Ἀραβίας “The land of Gesem of Arabia” (also in Gen 46:34), and this is apparently the result of their familiarity with: **גֶּשֶׁם הָעֲרָבִי** - “Geshem the Arabian”, or in the LXX: **Γησαμ ὁ Ἀραβί**” (Gesam the Arabi) of the Book of Nehemiah (Neh 2:19; 6:1).

In the Book of Isaiah we read the expression: **אֲרָם מִקְדָּם וּפְלִשְׁתִּים מֵאַחֲרָם** - “**The Arameans on the east, and the Philistines on the west**” (Is 9:11). However, the Greek translator wrote here: “Syria from the rising of the sun, and the Greeks from the setting of the sun.”

It was indicated by Tov, that the Greek translations of the books of Esther and Daniel are much “freer” than that of other biblical texts. As these are among the most recent additions to the Hebrew Bible, we may wonder, whether the translators felt more confident about their comprehension of these almost contemporary texts, and allowed themselves somewhat more freedom and carried out an idiomatic translation. Furthermore, while in the Hebrew version of the Book of Esther God is never mentioned, His name appears several times in the Greek version of that book.

It appears that at least some of the Greek translators (or the scribes who copied the translated texts) added explanatory notes. For example in the Book of Exodus we read:

כָּל-הַנֹּגֵעַ בָּהָר מוֹת יוֹמָת.

לֹא-תִגַּע בּוֹ יָד, כִּי-סָקוֹל יִסְקַל אוֹ-יָרֵה יִירֶה--אִם-בַּהֲמָה אִם-אִישׁ לֹא יִחְיֶה;

“Whosoever touches the mount shall be surely put to death;

No hand shall touch it, but he shall surely be stoned, or shot through; whether it be beast or man, it shall not live” (Ex 19”12-13).

The Greek translator wrote here:

“Everyone who touches the mountain shall die by death.

A hand shall not touch it. For he shall be stoned with stones or shot with an arrow, whether animal or whether human, it shall not live”

Although “stones” or “arrow” are not mentioned in the Hebrew version of these verses, it appears that the translator (or a scribe that copies the translated texts) ‘introduced’ into the Septuagint these words to explain the Hebrew **סָקוֹל יִסְקַל** (*saqol isaqel*) - “surly be pelted” and **יָרֵה יִירֶה** (*yaroh iareh*) – “surely be shot.” However, as stones could also be shot (Job 38:6; 2 Ch 26:15), it is possible that even the phrase **יָרֵה יִירֶה** (*yaroh iareh*) was “introduced” earlier into the Hebrew text by a scribe who wanted to explain the phrase **סָקוֹל יִסְקַל** (*saqol isaqel*) - “surly be pelted.”

There is evidence that the theological beliefs of the Greek translators found their way to their work. Here are several examples:

In the Book of Exodus we read:

**ויעל משה ואהרן--נדב ואביהוא, ושבעים מזקני ישראל.
ויראו את אלהי ישראל; ותחת רגליו כמעשה לבנת הספיר,**

**“Then went up Moses, and Aaron, Nadab, and Abihu, and seventy of the elders of Israel;
And they saw the God of Israel; and there was under His feet the like of a paved work of
sapphire stone” (Ex 24:9-10).**

The Greek translator wrote here:

“And they saw the place, there where the God of Israel stood.”

It seems that the reason for this change was the translators’ belief that humans could not see God (see also: Num 12:8).

The Greek version of verse 139:19 of the Book of Psalms indicates that the translators knew that the exact meaning of the Hebrew word **תקטל** is “you kill.” Yet in the Book of Job where Job refers to God: **לא (לו) איחל - הן יקטלני**, - “**Though He slay me, yet will I trust in Him**” (Job 13:15), the translators apparently could not bring themselves to write that Job was wishing to be killed by God, and they wrote instead: “Though the Mighty One overpower me.”

From the 1st century AD gradually the importance of the Greek translation grew among Christians, and at the same time it declined among Jews. It is possible that the beliefs of the later Christian scribes found their way to the copied text.

For example in the Hebrew version of Isaiah 7:14 we read:

לכן יתן אדני הוא לכם--אות: הנה העלמה הרה וילדת בן, וקראת שמו עמנו אל.

**“Therefore the Lord Himself shall give you a sign: behold, the young woman shall conceive,
and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.”**

The Greek translators wrote here:

“Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Look the virgin shall be with child and bear a son, and you shall name him Emmanouel.”

Although the Hebrew word **עלמה** (*almah*) appears in the Bible several times, this is the only place where the Greeks translated it to: “virgin.” The theological implications of such a translation become obvious when we find that this verse of Isaiah is quoted also in Matthew 1:23. It should be noted that in the Dead Sea Scroll of Isaiah (1st century BC-1st century AD) this word appears as *alma* (maiden), and not as *bethula* (virgin).

In the book of Job we read:

קרא-נא, היש עונך; ואל-מי מקדשים תפנה.

**“Call now; is there any that will answer you? And to which of the holy ones wilt you turn?”
(Job 5:1)**

The Greek translator wrote here:

“But call, if anyone will respond to you, or if you will see any of the holy angels”

However, angels are not mentioned in the Hebrew version of this verse, nor “holy angels” appear anywhere in the Hebrew Bible.

It appears that Christian theology affected also the translation of the Book of Psalms as in:

נורא אלהים ממקדשיו אל ישראל-- הוא נתן עז ותעצמות לעם ; ברוך אלהים.

“Awesome is God. From Your holy places to Israel, He gives strength and power to the people; Blessed be God” (Ps 68:36).

The Greek translator wrote here:

“Admirable is God among his saints; the God of Israel, he gives power and strength to his people.”

The concept of saints is rather alien to the spirit of the Hebrew Bible. When we hear the Psalmist saying:

יִקְנְאוּ לְמֹשֶׁה בַּמַּחֲנֶה ; לְאַהֲרֹן קָדוֹשׁ יְהוָה.

“They were jealous also of Moses in the camp, and of Aaron the holy one of YHWH” (Ps 106:16),

it does not mean that Aaron was a saint but rather that he was designated to minister to God (Ex 29:1).

The English speaking Jewish reader generally uses the Bible of the New Jewish Publication Society (NJPS), last revised in 1999. It was created by an “**Idiomatic translation**,” which has many advantages as well as disadvantages. As English and Hebrew have very different syntax and grammar, idiomatic translation transmits the spirit of the text much better than a literal translation. But the idiomatic translation is good only when the translator fully understand the original Hebrew text. Unfortunately, the language of the Hebrew Bible is not always clear. Furthermore:

The Bible was written in an ancient society that had fundamentally different literary conventions from ours.

Of the 304,901 words of the Hebrew Bible, 4,828 are in Aramaic, and discounting repetition, there are about 8,000 different Hebrew words in the whole Bible. Prof. Chaim Rabin indicated: “**The Bible deals with a restricted number of themes, and is not an encyclopedia** (or a lexicon).” The Hebrew vocabulary in biblical times most probably amounted to more than 30,000, but the biblical authors had no reason to use most of these words (C. Rabin. A short history of the Hebrew language. Pub. Jewish Agency. Jerusalem. 1973). A case in point is the following. Archeological studies indicate that cats became an integral element of the human household as early as the fifth millennium BC (or even earlier). Yet there is no known word in the Hebrew Bible that refers to this animal.

There are about 1500 words that appear in the Hebrew Bible only once (Hapax legomena - **מילים יחידאיות**). Naftali Herz Tur-Sinai indicated that several of them are “ghost words” resulting from spelling errors (N. H. Tur-Sinai. *Halashon Vehasefer*. 1954. In Hebrew), and Frederick Greenspahn claimed that there are no more than 322 absolute Hapax legomena (F. E. Greenspahn. *Hapax legomena in biblical Hebrew*. Scholars Press. Chico, California. 1984. p. 33). Several other words, although appear in the Hebrew Bible more than once, occur exclusively in single verses or in separate verses that appear to be copies of a single verse (H. R. Cohen. *Biblical Hapax Legomena in the light of Akkadian and Ugaritic*. Scholars Press 1978). The meaning of more than a few of such once-appearing words is not sure or known.



A Synonym words list written in cuneiform script on a clay tablet. From the library of the Neo-Assyrian king Ashurbanipal (668-627 BC).

Biblical synonymous words that sound similar are, in all likelihood, the result of a spelling error.

Spelling error can sometimes result in a real word. If the new word is not absolutely alien to the contextual information, some readers (as well as computer word spellers), would not recognize the change and would accept the distorted meaning of the text as genuine.



An egg of the Common Cuckoo in the nest of a Reed Warbler

Spelling errors had altered some words in such a way that they now appear as derivatives of other legitimate words. When ancient texts are employed to bring to light a language that was almost forgotten, such “Cuckoo’s egg type” words can obtain, from the content of the text where they appear in, additional but erroneous meanings.

Here are several examples:

ולא נטשתני לנשק לבני ולבנותי;

“And did not you suffer me to kiss my sons and my daughters” (Gen 31:28).

ויאמר איש-האלהים אנה נפל; ויראהו את-המקום, ויקצב-עץ וישלך-שמה, ויצף הברזל.

“And the man of God said: 'Where fell it?' And he showed him the place. And he cut down a stick, and cast it in thither, and made the iron to swim.” (2 Ki 6:6).

לקצבי הרים ירדתי,

“I went down to the bottoms of the mountains” (Jon 2:7).

הנטע אזן, הלא ישמע;

“He that planted the ear, shall He not hear” (Ps 94:9).

It is possible that some misspelled words that appeared early in the most ancient texts of the Bible were not recognized as such by the writers of the more recent biblical texts. These writers may have considered these phantom words as part of the vocabulary no longer used by the Hebrew speakers of their time. It is not unlikely that for literary purposes these writers, when they believed that their comprehension of such “words” was correct, have employed them, and their derivatives, in the biblical texts that they themselves composed.

The Talmudic sages used several methods for comprehending the Hebrew Bible. One such method was: **פשט** (*Peshat*) which is the understanding of the Hebrew words according to the common syntax and grammar, the content of the text, and the meaning of words from the same

root in other biblical texts. The sages used also three other methods, of which the more important one was **דרש** (*derash*), a technique that was based on text-induced impressions in certain authoritative readers and that was not necessarily dependent on the literary meaning of the words. The **דרש** (*derash*) technique might have been an adaptation of the Greek ἀλληγορία (*allegoria*) - “other-speak” or of allegories found in the Hebrew Bible (e.g. Ezekiel chapters 16-17). In the present manuscript we will try to comprehend the biblical text strictly according to the **פשט** (*Peshat*) method.